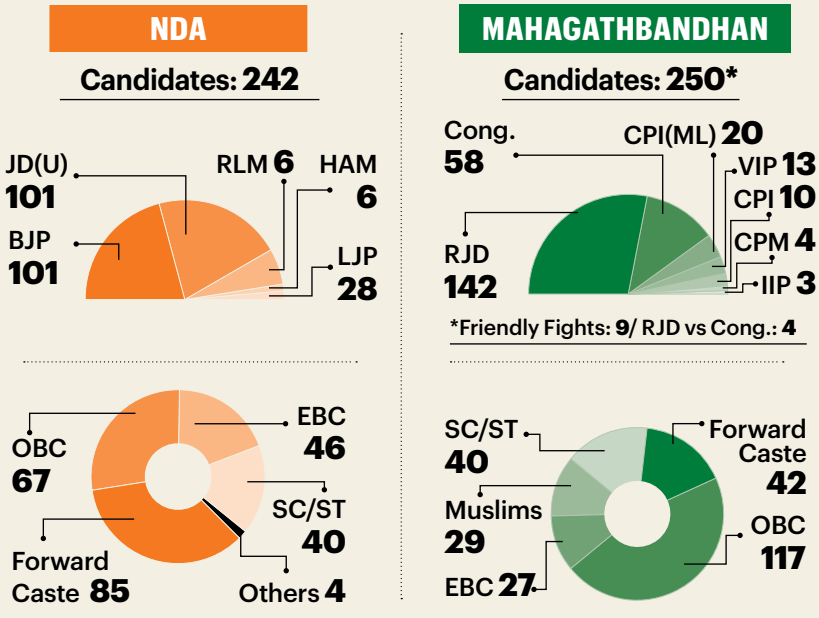


ANI

THE BATTLEFIELD

The seat distribution and caste break-up in the two alliances



wasted no time posting the Nitish clip on social media—these days, he pulls no punches while pointing to his opponents' eccentricities. But for oddities, he only needed to look at the space where he's Protagonist No. 1. At least till October 23, the last day for withdrawal of nominations, when he was at long last declared the MGB's consensus face for chief minister. That not only met a key demand, it filled an odd gap for an alliance whose two biggest stars—Tejashwi and Rahul Gandhi—had biked around Bihar like fast friends barely two months ago. Mukesh Sahani of the Vikassheel Insaan Party (VIP), who was playing the unstable electron, too, has been placated by being named as deputy CM face. More crucially, the Grand Alliance had a dozen seats where friends were pointing firearms at each other, so to speak. The last-minute peace mission managed to whittle that down—but only to nine. Ambition needs space to grow, and that's a finite resource even in the 243-seat Bihar assembly map.

The lack of mutual adoration is more oblique in the NDA. Its internal schisms didn't ever spill over into constituency-level fights. But for the usual quantum of rebel candidates that every side faces, it had a neat arrangment. Yet they look less like partners, more like pugilists shadow boxing each other warily. At its heart is a formative tension: the JD(U) has never been short of pangs of existential dread, especially among its old Samata Party cohort, who fear predation by its expansionist national ally should the chips fall in unfavourable ways. Chirag Paswan of the Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) keeps the mix even more combustible.

What keeps it all sutured together is only the figurehead of Nitish, whose loyal vote base everyone could use right now. And yet, the BJP has not declared him the NDA's CM face—deferring that choice to a post-poll scenario. The MGB, having made amends belatedly with Tejashwi's coronation, is now zeroing in on this to claim moral high ground.

Maha Gadbad?

Meanwhile, the muddle in the MGB over seat-sharing risked going down in history as a full-blown case of that good, old ingredient of tragedies: hubris. The local landlord, RJD, had gone ahead and unveiled a full slate of 143 names—only one less than 2020. One cancellation trimmed that to 142. The Congress announced 60 candidates. Among the smaller allies, the CPI(ML) named 20; Sahani's VIP 14 after one cancellation; the CPI, 10; the CPI(M), four; and I.P. Gupta's Indian Inclusive Party (IIP,) three.

That is, till October 23, the MGB had 253 candidates across 241 seats! Part-